

MAN OF LAW B.R. Ambedkar



Courtesy: Nehru Memorial Museum and Library

In his 1949 speech before the Assembly, the chairman of the Drafting Committee of the Constituent Assembly, Bhimrao Ambedkar, had said, "If things go wrong under the new Constitution the reason will not be that we had a bad Constitution. What we will have to say is that man was vile." He revived the Scheduled Caste Federation prior to the 1952 polls, describing the Congress as a *dharamshala* "open to fools and knaves, friends and foes".

"HELLO, HERO, HOW ARE YOU?"

Gyan Mukherjee's *Sangram* did the unthinkable—showed the hero playing a bad police officer who murders a girl he loves, shoots a policeman and gambles. Banned by chief minister Morarji Desai in its 16th week for being too violent, it solidified Ashok Kumar's status as a leading man. Ashok Kumar believed actors "belong to the lower strata of life", and yet went on to become such a star that even Jawaharlal Nehru would ask him: "Hello, hero, *kaise ho?*" (Hello, hero, how are you?) He started at Rs 250 and was earning Rs 2.5 lakh by the time the studio system ended.



K.M. PANNIKAR Historian, after meeting Mao Zedong

"He is pleasant and the look in his eyes kindly. There's no cruelty or hardness in his eyes or in his expression."

7 denominations in which coins were introduced. These included one rupee, half rupee, quarter rupee, two anna, one anna, half anna and pice.

49 lakh refugees assisted at the end of the year representing 98 per cent of the total displaced.



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Iron Age Ends

Sardar Patel died in December 1950. In his tribute to the man who united India, Nehru called him, "an unmatched warrior in the cause of freedom, a lover of India, a great servant of the people and a statesman of genius and mighty achievement".

ELSEWHERE...

- Author George Orwell, 46, died in London of tuberculosis.
- The FBI began its "10 Most Wanted" list after a reporter asked agents for names and descriptions of the "toughest guys" the FBI would like to capture.
- Jordan annexed the West Bank and offered citizenship to all Palestinians wishing to claim it.
- The Korean War (below) began as forces from the communist North invaded the South. It lasted till 1953.

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